

BEFORE

The Asian mainland was the origin of Japan's first settlers and the source of later cultural and technological developments.

THE FIRST JAPANESE

The first inhabitants of Japan arrived from the Asian mainland around 30,000 BCE. By 8,000 BCE they were producing distinctive **jomon** (rope-patterned) pottery—possibly the first pottery made anywhere in the world. These early Japanese were hunter-gatherers.



JOMON POTTERY

ASIAN INFLUENCES

Around 300 BCE, the arrival of rice from East Asia revolutionized Japanese society. **Rice cultivation** required a peasant workforce living in settled communities. Large landowners became **regional rulers** who fought for access to water and fertile land. In the 6th–7th centuries CE, contact with Asia brought the Buddhist religion and with it **Chinese high culture** << 160–61 including writing in the form of Chinese characters.

FUJIWARA JAPAN

Japan's line of **sacred emperors** is historically attested after the 3rd century CE. During the **Heian Period** (794–1185 CE), power devolved from the emperor to the **Fujiwara clan**, which controlled the imperial court and **dominated Japan** until the rise of the samurai.

BUSHIDO A code of conduct and a way of life practiced by the samurai. Bushido sought to unite learning and military prowess, and emphasized frugality, loyalty, mastery of martial arts and, above all, honor.

Twelfth-century Japan was a country with an elaborate, subtle, artistic culture that was developed at the imperial court in the capital, Kyoto. But in many areas outside the capital, life was lawless and unruly. In many provinces, clans (extended families) of samurai warriors ruled by force. Among the most powerful of them were two long-established families of high standing, the Minamoto and Taira. Their ancestors had been imperial princes who, in the 9th century, were dispatched from Kyoto to uphold the emperor's authority in distant provinces. There, fighting men flocked to serve them, and the two families became leaders of powerful warrior clans. From their provincial bases, in the 12th century the Minamoto and Taira returned to compete for supreme power in the capital, Kyoto.

Gempei Wars

As the dominant family at the imperial court, the Taira at first had the upper hand. But, between 1180 and 1185 a series of fierce conflicts, known as the Gempei Wars, ended with the Minamoto family triumphant. At two decisive battles, in 1184 and 1185, the Taira were slaughtered in combat, driven to mass suicide, or captured and

“It is not the **way of the warrior** to be shamed and avoid death.”

SAMURAI TORII MOTOTADA, 1600

executed. Minamoto Yoritomo (see right), the head of the Minamoto clan, was established as the country's first military dictator, or “shogun,” with his court at Kamakura, far to the east of Kyoto. The emperor was left in the old capital as a powerless figurehead.

Shogun rule

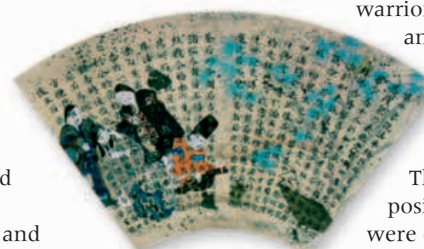
The rule of the shoguns, which was to continue until the mid-19th century, established the samurai as the dominant military and social elite. Originally rough fighting men at odds with the effete culture of the court, the samurai evolved into a striking mixture of the savage and the refined. The ideal warrior was as capable of dashing off a poem as he was of slicing off an enemy's head with his two-handed sword. In theory he subscribed to an

austere code of honor and, rather than face defeat, would commit ritual suicide (*seppuku*) by cutting open the stomach (*hara kiri*). Warfare between samurai followed brutal but elaborate rules—for example, it was customary to cut off the head of a warrior you killed in battle and return it to his family stuck on a spiked board.

Fighting men

The dominant social position of men who were devoted to war as a way of life inevitably spawned violence in a country that had no external enemies. The sole foreign threat in the medieval period

came from China. In 1274 and again in 1281, China's Mongol ruler, Kublai Khan (see p.165) attempted to invade Japan by sea from Korea. The samurai united to repel these invasions,



Fujiwara fan

Decorating fans was a typical activity of the refined court ladies.

The Rise of the Samurai

The samurai, an elite class of armored warriors, dominated Japan from the 12th century. Their fighting prowess and tradition of loyal service to the death—enshrined in the chivalric code of *bushido*—are the stuff of legend. But in reality, samurai ascendancy brought instability, violence, and civil war.



The Tale of Genji

Murasaki Shikibu's long novel *The Tale of Genji* was based on the author's experiences as lady-in-waiting at the imperial court in the early 11th century. It paints a vivid picture of Kyoto courtiers devoted to amorous intrigues and the delicate expression of emotions in verse.

Divine wind

The second attempt by the Mongols to invade Japan met with disaster. The Mongol fleet was scattered by a typhoon, remembered by the Japanese as the *kamikaze* (“divine wind”).